



VILLAGERS in Qlayaa, southern Lebanon, mourn Father Pierre al-Rahi during his funeral Wednesday.

RABIH DAHER AFP/Getty Images

Record heat is forecast for L.A.

Temps could be 30 degrees over average. Officials worry more about health than fire.

By Grace Toohey

A potentially dangerous, record-setting heat wave this week is forecast to spike temperatures to the year's highest mark yet, bringing discourse in Southern California back to one of its most infamous concerns: wildfire.

The unseasonable heat this week won't create conditions extreme enough to fuel a fast-moving fire or issue a red flag warning, but local officials say they are gearing up for the possibility of small grass fires — and, if this warm pattern lingers, an earlier start to the region's most active fire season.

"The longer this warm stretch lasts, it's going to speed up the whole drying and curing process," said Ryan Kittell, a meteorologist with the National Weather Service in Oxnard.

Thursday and Friday are forecast to see the highest temperatures this week, with much of the region seeing highs in the 90s and a few spots hitting triple digits, Kittell said. Those temperatures, 20 to 30 degrees above average for this time of year, mark another stretch of unseasonably hot weather, a pattern that Kittell said will probably last for at least another week, if not longer.

[See Heat, A6]

RV rage, and then a death

A Sylmar man who shared online his frustration with homeless people is now charged in killing

By Matthew Ormseth



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

DILAPIDATED RVs line San Fernando Road in Pa-coima, near where a homeless man was fatally shot.

From his second-floor apartment that overlooked a stretch of road in Sylmar lined with broken-down RVs, Vincent Wolf fumed.

"They s— and piss on the street," Wolf, 23, wrote on Instagram in August, according to a search warrant affidavit. "They do drugs in the middle of the night. They f—ing screamed for no reason. And most importantly violent."

Wolf, a construction worker who lived with his mother and aunt in a run-down apartment complex off Foothill Boulevard, vented in Instagram comments about the city's handling of the homelessness crisis.

"It's all corrupt politicians left nor right," he was quoted as writing in the affidavit, which was filed in Los Angeles County Superior Court in August. "Elderly people in the young don't deserve none of this."

[See Homelessness, A6]

A PRIEST SLAIN IN UNWANTED WAR

Christians and other minorities in Lebanon find themselves caught in Israel-Hezbollah crossfire

By Nabih Bulos

REPORTING FROM QLAYAA, LEBANON

The bells rang, their peals obscuring the buzz of the Israeli drone overhead as the casket of Father Pierre al-Rahi arrived at the parish he had served.

Only days before, Al-Rahi had stood in the very churchyard where the crowd assembled Wednesday for his funeral. He had announced that the people of Qlayaa would ignore Israel's evacuation orders for southern Lebanon and remain.

"He gave us strength to stay rooted here. He kept repeating, 'We're staying,'" said Eveline Farah, a 67-year-old resident.

And he had lived up to his word, Farah added. So when an Israeli tank shell struck a house in the village on Monday, Al-Rahi and others rushed to help the elderly couple living there.

That was when the second shell struck, wounding Al-Rahi and five others. He bled to death later that day, bringing

home to Qlayaa, one of the few Christian-majority areas in Lebanon's south, the latest conflict between Israel and the Islamic militants of Hezbollah. It's a war no one here wants.

"No one in Qlayaa is fighting. There's no Hezbollah here. They want to fight, let them. It has nothing to do with us," said Najla Farah, 39, a distant relative of Eveline Farah.

As the funeral procession approached the churchyard, a group of women tossed rose petals and rice. Others surged toward the casket, dancing, clapping, ululating; all through tears.

"Get up, Father Pierre. Get up!" shouted one elderly woman as she stood in the pallbearers' path, her screams turning her voice hoarse as she partially collapsed in the arms of a medic.

"You're not [See Lebanon, A3]

Sheriff's deputy was paid even after his conviction

By Salvador Hernandez

A Los Angeles County deputy who was convicted of excessive force continued to collect a paycheck for months even though he was barred from carrying a badge in California, according to Sheriff's Department officials and county records.

A federal jury convicted Trevor Kirk in February 2025 of a felony after he was recorded throwing a woman face first onto the ground outside a supermarket in Lancaster.

Kirk, 33, was sentenced to four months in prison and his certification as a law enforcement officer was revoked by the Commission on Peace Officer Standards and Training, in effect banning him from working as a police officer in the state.

But Kirk remained employed with the Sheriff's Department for months afterward, collecting benefits and a six-figure salary. Kirk had been relieved of duty after the 2023 encounter and was off the streets and had no other duties assigned in the department, a department spokesperson said.

Now, the Los Angeles County Sheriff's Civilian Oversight Commission is tasking the Sheriff's Department to draft a policy to determine how to handle the firing of deputies who have been decertified and can no longer serve as peace officers in California.

Kirk's attorney, Tom Yu, did not respond to a request for comment.

Kirk was relieved of duty in July 2023. In a recording that surfaced weeks earlier, Kirk was seen responding to a report of a robbery and being approached by a woman [See Deputy, A7]

Voters unsure in L.A. mayor race

Incumbent Karen Bass leads in a new poll, but with just 20% support. CALIFORNIA, B1

Parasite threat found in state

Rat lungworm can cause neurological illness and meningitis in people. SCIENCE, A8

Adebayo's 83 nice but empty

His feat doesn't compare to Bryant's 81, Mirjam Swanson writes. SPORTS, B10

Weather Sunshine. L.A. Basin: 91/64. B6

Markets A11 Opinion Voices A12

For the latest news, go to latimes.com.



7 85944 00200 5

Nations release oil reserves as ships attacked

Global energy concerns rising as an important strait is in effect shut down.

By Kevin Rector

Attacks on multiple commercial ships in the waters around Iran on Wednesday increased global energy concerns, pushed nations to unleash strategic oil reserves and sparked fresh critiques of the Trump administration's readiness for a war it started.

As Trump administration and U.S. military officials continued to claim increasing success and advantage in the conflict — and authorities downplayed a reported threat of drone attacks on California — leaders around the world scrambled to respond to the latest attacks and the International Energy Agency's call for the largest-ever release of strategic oil reserves by its members to help stem energy price spikes.

President Trump also faced renewed questions about a deadly strike on an Iranian elementary school at the start of the war, after the New York Times reported Wednesday that a military investigation had determined the U.S. was responsible.

"I don't know about it," Trump said when asked about the report.

In an address Wednesday

morning, IEA Executive Director Fatih Birol said energy shipments through the Strait of Hormuz had "all but stopped" amid the conflict, driving massive global competition for oil and gas in wealthier countries and fuel rationing in poorer nations.

He said the IEA's 32 member nations have brought a "sense of urgency and solidarity" to recent discussions on the matter, and had unanimously agreed to "launch the largest-ever release of emergency oil stocks in our agency's history," making 400 million barrels of oil available.

However, he said the most needed change is the "resumption of traffic through the Strait of Hormuz."

Several countries, including Germany, Austria and Japan, had already confirmed their plans to release reserves.

The United States, an IEA member, will release 172 million barrels, the Associated Press reported.

Trump said Wednesday afternoon at an event in Kentucky that he was "pleased" with the IEA plan, which he said would "sub-

[See Iran, A3]

A caution about drone attacks

California could be targeted by Iran, memo says, but sources downplay threat. NATION, A5



Royal Thai Navy

A THAI cargo ship spews smoke after coming under attack Wednesday in the Strait of Hormuz near Iran.

For 3 critical days, warnings ignored

Testimony details how LAFD leaders missed chances to avert the Palisades inferno.

By Alene Tchekmedyan

Jacob Ulibarri spent about six hours on New Year's Day last year squashing hot spots where the Lachman fire had burned.

The rookie Los Angeles firefighter arrived sometime after 7 a.m., when the smoky areas were all over and easy to see. By the time the next crew swapped with his that afternoon, they were scarcer: "One every 30 minutes, roughly," Ulibarri recalled.

At that point, Battalion Chief Martin Mullen, who was running the mop-up operation, had walked three laps around the perimeter of the fire. He recalled one hot spot he saw about 10 a.m., which crews hit with water. Later in the afternoon, Mullen did his fourth and last loop and left the area for good.

He decided to leave the hoses out overnight, just in case.

Over the next two days, a series of communication failures and questionable decisions led crews to leave the area prematurely, with embers from the small Jan. 1 fire later reigniting into the devastating Palisades fire. A firefighter picking up hoses on Jan. 2 found crackling,

red-hot coals in the dirt and warned colleagues that a more thorough mop-up was needed. Also that morning, a captain cautioned his chief that it was too soon to pick up the hoses. In yet another missed opportunity, crews apparently did not walk the entire perimeter of the burn scar after a caller reported smoke in the area on Jan. 3.

The revelations, contained in the sworn testimony of a dozen firefighters this year as part of a lawsuit filed by Palisades fire victims, corroborate previous reporting by The Times and call into question the Los Angeles Fire Department's repeated claims that commanders left the fire "dead out." More than a year later, with much of Pacific Palisades still in ruins, LAFD leaders have refused to explain how or why the breakdowns occurred.

The firefighters' depositions offer the clearest timeline yet of how LAFD leaders dealt with the Lachman fire and reached their decision to treat the fire as extinguished, despite the red flags raised by some firefighters.

Because of the holiday, some at the Lachman scene were filling in for others outside of their normal assignments. Firefighters said they adhered to the LAFD's strict chain of command and did not question higher-ups, while those in charge had fuzzy memories or shifted responsibility to others.

[See Fire, A7]